By the early 80s, solidarity aid for the PLO reached DDM6 million, most provided in the form of medication, plasma, tents, hygiene equipment and blankets. As a result of the Israeli attack on Beirut in the summer of 1982, over forty Palestinian paramilitaries were flown to East Berlin for medical care.7

Over time, the GDR forged South Yemen into a bridge between the African and the Arab world and, according to Wolf, Aden became a ‘playground’ for a large corps of East German advisers. Encouraged by Moscow, East Berlin provided Yemen with economic, military and intelligence advisors – and from Aden spread their tentacles to Angola, Ethiopia and Mozambique, where the MfS taught locals about counterespionage and the deterrence of smuggling.

By 1981, East German military and civilian advisors were spread out across Congo, Guinea, Mali, Tanzania, Algeria, Iraq, North Yemen, South Yemen and Syria.8 Especially strong relations were secured with Libya which purchased military technology on a cash basis, while colonel Ghaddafi’s personal guard received intensive training at the Kallinchen facility near Berlin. At the same time, advisers from the MfS organised Libya’s internal security system and paid particular attention to protecting Ghaddafi.9

Throughout the 70s, the Stasi also had murky dealings with members of the infamous Red Army Faction (RAF) terrorist group by providing them with safe passage via Schönefeld Airport to other countries or training camps in the Middle East. From 1970 to 78, it was estimated that the RAF and other organisations committed to violence, were responsible for over thirty bank robberies and the deaths of twenty-eight people, the wounding of eighty others and the taking of over 160 hostages. RAF members received training in the use of firearms and hand grenades, and some former members even moved to East Germany because they wanted to give up the armed struggle and rebuild their lives. Honecker – according to testimony from Minister Peter-Michael Diestel in the late 1980s – offered terrorists a new identity, work, accommodation and privileges of the communist elite, such as diplomatic passports.10

Only a few MfS employees, in addition to Stasi boss Erich Mielke, were privy to such dark shenanigans, though Honecker later denied any